



MONTHLY UPDATE

Zambia: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-31 • 72 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH • GOVERNANCE • FINANCE • ICT INFRASTRUCTURE • DPI • DIGITALISATION • TECHNOLOGY
• CAPACITY • INCLUSION • DATA • GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Enforcement of the Cyber Crimes Act No. 4 of 2025 was declared fully operational on 18 July 2026, twenty-six days before the general election of 13 August ([enforcement account](#)). In the same weeks the state extended its collection systems to local government, reporting about K21.7 million from eight of 116 councils in their first month ([collection figures](#)), and launched a government-owned private 4G network for public institutions ([launch account](#)).

The month closed with the state ICT institute confirming that four named border posts still lack the connectivity the government network was meant to provide ([status update](#)).

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The head of the Presidential Delivery Unit said on 17 July 2026 that Zambia's National AI Strategy was nearing completion and invited stakeholder contributions ([statement](#)). Against that, a continental review published on 1 July reads a Zambian national AI strategy alongside six others as an existing analysable text. Nothing on file settles whether a draft has been circulated to researchers without being published, or whether the review is in error.

Legislation and regulation

Public consultation on the Postal and Courier Services Bill closed on 27 July, one working day after ten-province stakeholder consultations concluded. A ministry representative separately named a forthcoming Startup Bill on 17 July — the first and only mention of that Bill in the base.

Data protection

The data-protection regulator exists and travels; nothing in the base shows it acting. It joined a multi-sectoral delegation to the continental identity conference, and on 31 July [nine civil society organisations asked it to examine the source of the contact list behind SMS messages sent to social cash transfer beneficiaries](#) before the 13 August election. No response from the Office is on the record. No registration count, enforcement decision, fine, breach notification, guidance note or annual report is held for it at any date. The Data Protection Act 2021 remains in force and was [named by the information ministry on 18 July as one of three instruments regulating online communications, cybersecurity and personal data](#); the reported Cabinet intention to repeal it has produced nothing on the record in sixteen months.

What is being built for it is a system rather than a case. The World Bank-financed acceleration project [opened tender on 10 August, closing 21 August, for a digital data-protection compliance management system to serve the Commission](#), to integrate with the government service bus and payment gateway and to meet ISO/IEC 27001, ISO/IEC 27701 and WCAG 2.1 AA, alongside a [parallel tender to review the national data-protection guidelines and compliance frameworks](#). Tenders rather than awards, and neither states a value, a delivery date, or the caseload the system would manage.

Regional collaboration

A [Zambian was elected Secretary-General of the African Telecommunications Union at Abuja on the fourth round with 21 of 34 votes](#), taking office on 1 January 2027 for four years — while Zambia was not elected to the 25-member administrative council for the coming cycle, gaining the continental secretariat and losing the council seat together. Separately a [regional central bank spokesperson said four states including Zambia are considering onboarding their currencies to the regional settlement system, potentially by end-2027](#); nothing establishes that the Bank of Zambia has decided, and the electronic clearing house is separately reported as not yet live on the regional instant-payment scheme.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The same Postal and Courier Services Bill consultation — the only open public call for written comment on a Zambian instrument the wiki holds for the whole window — closed three days after the call for written submissions was reported, with no submission count, published response or consultation report held.

On 1 August the Human Rights Commission disclosed that its case review meeting had considered 105 alleged violations linked to the election period, of which 62 were resolved administratively.

The election itself, on 13 August, produced the fullest external account of the country's digital systems the base holds. Observer missions recorded a [hybrid digital and manual voter-registration system with an online pre-registration portal, logging 8,786,300 registered voters, up 25% since 2021](#). A domestic coalition [found election-day process largely transparent but flagged an online-only accreditation system that blocked 11 accredited monitors, and the electoral commission's refusal to share the voters register](#). The European mission found online free expression unduly curtailed under the 2025 Cyber Security Act amid arrests for speech offences, and a regional media institute [recorded a journalist detained for two weeks under the Cyber Crimes Act and judged the access-to-information law and decriminalised defamation paper victories undermined by the two 2025 statutes](#). These are preliminary statements; no final report, government response or commission account of the accreditation and register decisions is held.

Finance

New investments

On 27 July a domestic digital lender [reported more than K500 million lent to over 120,000 customers since founding, and committed a further K500 million over the next decade](#) — a forward intention by the lender itself, with no external financier named.

External money made a smaller and vaguer offer. On 11 August the United Kingdom [opened expressions of interest for a Southern Africa science and technology accelerator worth up to GBP2.5m to March 2030](#), naming Zambia with Zimbabwe as the first year's focus and South Africa as the programme's primary one. No Zambian allocation is stated, and the delivery consortium has not been chosen.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

A government-owned shared 4G network for public institutions was launched at Ndola Teaching Hospital on 15 July 2026, run by the state ICT institute with three named partners and the health ministry ([launch account](#)). The reported outcomes are clinician accounts at the launch site; no baseline or measured result is held.

On 5 August the institute confirmed that connectivity gaps persist at Nakonde, Victoria Falls, Kazungula and Chirundu, and set a single national standard through the government network of tiered 10 to 100 Mbps bandwidth, dual links with automatic failover and enterprise-grade firewalls. A trade facilitation body has commissioned an audit of ICT infrastructure at five border posts; no budget, timetable or completion date is published, and the audit precedes the procurement rather than following it ([status update](#)).

The technology ministry [put the country at about 26.2 million mobile subscriptions in 2025, up from 23.2 million in 2024, with about 14.7 million mobile internet subscriptions](#) - its own figures, given in a seminar address rather than a regulator publication.

A further Northern Province district administration was connected in August, and the account is unusually specific about what a connection reached. After the provincial ICT unit installed connectivity at Lupososhi District Administration and ran a virtual orientation on the national portal and two office collaboration tools, an official [printed a road-tax document from his own office instead of travelling to Kasama for it, days before it expired](#). It is one office and one document: no district count, schedule or cost for the programme is published.

Cybersecurity

The Ministry of Information and Media declared the Cyber Crimes Act No. 4 of 2025 fully operational on 18 July 2026, warning that recording, publishing or distributing private communications without authorisation could bring prosecution and singling out public servants on confidential information. Compliance obligations were stated as extending to financial institutions, telecommunications operators, digital platforms, mobile money providers and e-commerce businesses ([enforcement account](#)). The declaration falls twenty-six days before the general election of 13 August. No prosecution, charge or conviction count has been published.

Three days earlier the cyber security agency had urged journalists to learn the cyber laws, framing them as protection for media houses against ransomware and disruption.

The regulator reported on 4 August that it had deactivated 43,500 SIM cards linked to mobile-money fraud and secured K19.8 million between January and June 2026, on consumer reports through a short code, with no breakdown by operator and no prior-period comparison ([regulator figures](#)).

DPI

Data Exchange

The government service bus, the central integration layer, onboarded eight of 116 local authorities from June 2026 and now carries more than 400 government services with over K8.8 billion collected cumulatively across the service bus, payment gateway, national portal and payment platform ([collection figures](#); [Accountant General's office](#)).

A register of a different kind opened alongside it. Zambia [launched a fully digital National Carbon Registry on 7 August](#), embedded in the national measurement, reporting and verification system and interoperable with Article 6 of the Paris Agreement, developed under a donor programme with a UN climate centre, a consulting group and a green growth institute. No public access, transaction count, custodian ministry or disclosure rule for its holdings is stated — which for a registry whose purpose is to make carbon claims checkable is the question it exists to answer.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Nothing published in the window moves the identity position. The most recent enrolment statement remains about 1.5 million of about 20 million people, roughly 7.5%, restated on 27 July ([switch account](#)), and biometric card issuance remains deferred until after the 13 August election.

Digital Payments and Fintech

On 27 July a vendor manager stated on the record that the National Financial Switch's intended reduction in customer transaction costs has not happened yet, that the central bank is only now focusing on it, and that the electronic clearing house is not yet live on the regional instant-payment scheme ([switch account](#)).

Retail participation in the securities market is the one digital adoption figure the month produced: registered users of the exchange's mobile trading application [rose to 51,791 in July from 49,611 in June](#). It is the exchange's own count of registered users, not of active traders or funded accounts.

The regional rail above the domestic one acquired its rules. The regional clearing house [published the scheme rulebook for instant low-cost cross-border retail payments, with a gender audit and strategy to 2030 drawn from research along the corridor with Malawi](#). No Zambian transaction volume, participant count or fee schedule is published.

Acceptance also widened from outside. A commercial bank and an international card scheme [opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards to participating merchants in nine African markets including Zambia on 19 August](#), settling in local currency, US dollars or both; the merchant count is given for the nine markets together and not for Zambia.

Registries

A [national carbon registry went live on 8 August](#) in its first phase, with every carbon-credit transaction in Zambia required to pass through it, administered by the environmental agency and linked to the national monitoring system and the UNFCCC accounting platform; a second phase is to add voluntary-market registration. No address, operating rules, access terms or naming of the legal instrument is published, and the counts given at the launch — more than 90 projects at stages of approval, and bilateral agreements with Sweden, Norway and Switzerland — are the permanent secretary's own. A [national spatial data infrastructure policy and portal were launched](#) on open-source software, cited as underpinning land mapping and artisanal mining licensing, with no dataset count, licence terms or usage figure held and the policy document itself not held. The land administration system is unchanged, and the Minister of Lands told Parliament that its [predecessor ran with no maintenance contract from 31 March 2022, creating a conduit for corruption](#).

Sectoral management information systems

The national electronic health record and its hospital tier are migrating onto the new shared 4G network, alongside the network's launch at Ndola Teaching Hospital ([launch account](#)).

Other GovTech and e-Gov

A contract tracking and management system was launched with the Ministry of Justice on 12 July for digital submission of government contracts to the Attorney General's Chambers and real-time tracking of approval progress; no volume or turnaround figure was published.

The other movement is at the far end of the network rather than the centre. The e-government agency's Northern Province unit is [onboarding government employees in Mpulungu, Mbala and Lupososhi districts onto an e-payslip self-service portal](#), replacing manual payslip distribution with round-the-clock access to employment records, and [has connected the Lupososhi district administration to the Government Wide Area Network and given it a wireless access point so officials can use internet calling and digital communication platforms rather than unreliable mobile coverage](#). The same unit is inspecting government office equipment and briefing officials on the Government Office Equipment Standards, which cover acquisition, registration, maintenance, use and disposal. No enrolment count, coverage figure or completion date accompanies any of it, so what is on record is a method reaching three districts.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The eight onboarded local authorities returned about K21.7 million in their first month, for property rates, business levies and permits, with Lusaka City Council urging business and property owners to use the platform on stated grounds of minimising revenue leakages ([collection figures](#)).

Rural digital data capture

Satellite kits [connected a rural health clinic and two primary schools in Moomba Chiefdom](#) to government services through the national portal. No national count of connected facilities is published, and the state's purchase of foreign satellite capacity for the last mile sits alongside its own private 4G build.

Technology

AI

The same 17 July statement disclosed an opportunity to establish Zambia's first artificial intelligence laboratory with the International Telecommunication Union, with no signature, funding, siting or timetable reported ([statement](#)). On 30 July the home affairs permanent secretary cited the cyber security agency's establishment as strengthening the response to online scams and artificial-intelligence-enabled trafficking, placing organised crime inside a cyber regulator's remit.

On 28 July an implementing partner published a first-hand account of automating public query handling at the National Assembly, consolidating budget and administrative data and surfacing information to members during debates and committee hearings. The same account reports parliamentary staff using public artificial intelligence tools on personal judgment, limited monitoring of what data flows into those platforms, and no consistent approach to hallucinations — findings the partner reports from two other African parliaments as well.

ICT Industry

The third edition of a continental diversity report puts [29% of Zambian startups sampled with at least one female co-founder, the highest of any country covered, and 22.6% with a female chief executive](#), against a continental 19.2% female co-founded from a sample of more than 3,000. The underlying report is not held; only the trade-press account is.

Innovation ecosystem

Three private ventures carry the innovation position, all on their own accounts. A [private hub ran the nine-month pipeline that took a Zambian team to the Geneva global finals](#) of the 2026 artificial-intelligence summit and youth robotics challenge among nearly 50 countries, its chief executive saying the talent pool is real and the investment in research and innovation is not. An [agritech pairs satellite imagery with artificial intelligence to route smallholders into premium markets](#), operating a virtual warehouse in which buyers specify variety, quality and compliance before planting. And a [roadside-assistance marketplace connects drivers to nearby providers](#) with in-app messaging and real-time geolocation. No user numbers, revenue, funding or independent evaluation is held for any of the three.

A donor-funded accelerator began staffing up: a private hub [called for facilitators and group coaches for a twelve-month incubator running masterclasses, group coaching and access to funding for digital startups](#). No cohort size, budget or start date is stated, and the government innovation fund the base looked for is still not held.

Capacity

Literacy

The state ICT institute, with the International Telecommunication Union and the youth ministry, [handed computers, a projector and an industrial printer to the Mpika Youth Resource Centre](#), with two further handovers named. No cost, contract term, procurement route or trainee count is published.

Training and skills

On 20 July the state ICT institute reported training 146 public officers across three district administrations of Southern Province; no cumulative national total is published.

Research institutions

The revenue authority signed a research memorandum with an international tax and development centre on 17 July, accompanied by a non-disclosure agreement, so whether taxpayer microdata moves is not disclosed.

Inclusion

Access to services

The same 27 July account puts financial inclusion at 80.1% of adults in 2025, with mobile money use at 76.2% ([switch account](#)).

Data

Open data

African telecommunications ministers [adopted the Abuja declaration on meaningful connectivity](#), defining it as regular access plus a suitable device, sufficient data and a connection fast enough for video learning and commerce, and committing signatories to review sector taxes, lower taxes on entry-level devices, incentivise local assembly and cut import tariffs on handsets under US\$50. No Zambian implementing measure follows it on the base.

Use of satellite data

A Zambian platform [pairs satellite imagery with artificial intelligence for smallholder traceability and market matching](#), built after commercial traceability software was quoted at thousands of dollars a month. The account is the founders' own, with no user count, revenue or independent verification held.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The United States health financing memorandum is reported shelved since May over data terms and a minerals precondition. A leaked five-year draft offered US\$1.012bn against commitments to hire 40,000 health workers, plus ten years of health-data access and a 25-year pathogen-data pledge; the Foreign Minister put the proposed agreement at up to US\$2bn, and the two values are not reconciled. No signature is on file, and the 25-year data term is reported from a leaked draft rather than a text the base holds.

China activities

A seminar on China-Zambia artificial-intelligence cooperation covered localising artificial-intelligence solutions to Zambian conditions and partnering with universities on curricula, and a ministry director and the Chinese ambassador discussed digital infrastructure, emerging technologies, skills and research. No agreement, value, timetable or named institution follows from either.

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